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Abstract

This essay responds to the characterization Ted Miller offers (in his December 2008 essay in *Political Theory*) of the kind of nonfoundationalism I have referred to as “weak ontology,” and that Gianni Vattimo frequently calls “weak thought.” Miller argues that such a position embodies, first, a philosophy of history in which strong ontologies (e.g., religion) are assessed categorically as passé, and, second, are associated essentially with violence. I show that while these characterizations may be appropriate for Vattimo’s thought, they are not for weak ontology as I understand it. Finally, I suggest that the former might more usefully be categorized as “antifoundationalism” and the latter as “nonfoundationalism.”

Keywords

foundationalism, weak ontology, violence, philosophy of history, late-modernity

In “The Two Deaths of Lady Macduff,” Ted Miller presents an engaging interpretation of William Davenant’s late-seventeenth-century version of Shakespeare’s *Macbeth*.¹ The revisions constitute a reflection on the monarchy’s Restoration in England in 1660. According to Miller, Davenant rewrote the character and death of Lady Macduff (the wife of one of Macbeth’s antagonists) to encourage Charles II in his decision not to accede to the appeals of hard-line Anglican leaders for a crusade against those who held

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dissenting religious views. These Anglicans argued that God had brought Charles to the throne, and that he should follow-up that manifestation of Providence and smite those who had toppled the established church and executed his father in the preceding civil war. Davenant urged the king not to engage in such a crusade, but rather to act in a Hobbesian fashion, seeking only the peace and safety of all his subjects, while demonstrating a willingness to violently suppress those who wished to reignite old conflicts.

Miller's reading of this revised *Macbeth* is intelligent and quite persuasive. I do not contest its basics. A problem emerges, however, when Miller uses this case to make broader claims about foundations in political theory. Specifically, he argues that Davenant's position throws some doubts on a variant of non-foundationalism I call "weak ontology."² According to Miller, I argue that weak-ontological positions emerge only in late-modernity, and that they set themselves off from strong-ontological ones by showing how the latter always tend toward violence. In short, the certainty a strong ontologist feels toward his foundations pairs naturally with a willingness to use violence against opponents. My thinking on these matters, Miller concludes, tends to parallel that of Gianni Vattimo, who has also referred to his nonfoundationalist position as "weak thought," or, less frequently, "weak ontology."³

I want to take issue with the way Miller aligns my weak ontology with Vattimo's, especially in regard to the issues of violence and philosophy of history (pp. 856-57). Miller's misunderstandings do not turn on narrow points of textual or historical interpretation; rather they raise matters of broad philosophical significance for how nonfoundationalism should be construed in contemporary political theory.

Let me turn first to the philosophy of history that supposedly underlies weak ontology. As Miller contends, I generally associate nonfoundationalist or weak-ontological positions with "late-modernity," on the one hand, and foundationalist or strong-ontological positions with Western modernity or premodernity, on the other. He finds that this "periodization is too simple, and too subservient to . . . Heidegger's narrative" about the modern West (p. 857). Davenant is interesting, because he undermines my periodization: he deployed "a form of weak ontology" already in the seventeenth century (p. 857). He rejected the strong-ontological, theistic claims of his Anglican opponents, contending that the safety of the realm trumped any claims about godly imperatives to suppress religious opponents.

The success of Miller's example depends on the persuasiveness of his assertions that Davenant was, in fact, a weak ontologist and that his case indeed confounds my association of weak ontology with late-modernity. As for the first assertion, I do not think that Miller really gives us enough of an

understanding of Davenant to determine if he had actually given up on foundationalist thinking. At one point, we are told that Davenant may have been a Catholic (p. 866). This admission opens the possibility that the playwright opposed the Anglican hard-liners and espoused peace and forgetting on the grounds that the strategy provided the safest route by which to protect the Catholic minority in England. Davenant could thus have taken the positions Miller ascribes to him on perfectly plausible, strong-ontological grounds.

I do not, however, want to press this possibility on Miller. Things are much more interesting if he is correct about Davenant's being a weak ontologist. And even if Davenant was not, I feel confident that someone in seventeenth-century England probably was; and thus I had better be prepared to explain what such a possibility implies for my claims about weak ontology's appearance in late-modernity.

In my view, part of what constitutes the concept of late-modernity is the growing prevalence of nonfoundationalism. But that claim in no way necessarily implies that no one was a nonfoundationalist before, say, Nietzsche. I see no reason why Davenant's case should throw my periodization into question. Davenant is simply an exception to the rule. As Miller himself says: "It is surprising when persons in the seventeenth century do not see the hand of God in events" (p. 870).

I suspect that what really bothers Miller—as it should—is his fear that my periodization rests on a philosophy of history that sees the shift from foundationalism to nonfoundationalism as a kind of unambiguous progress toward greater truth. Presumably, it is this sense of progress that leads nonfoundationalists to assume that they will eschew the violence they associate with ignorant foundationalists. Miller uses Davenant to show that this assumption by nonfoundationalists of their own opposition to violence is unwarranted. One can be against foundationalism and yet for violence. Vattimo and I, however, fail to see this; we miss the fact that commitment to nonfoundationalism is "largely independent" from a commitment either for or against violence (p. 876).

Actually, I side with Miller on this matter. The source of my distance from Vattimo arises from the fact that my periodization is not a philosophy of history, whereas his is. My position is that there is indeed good sense in delineating a crucial shift in the modern West that warrants speaking today of "late-modernity." I would refer in a comparable fashion to shifts like the Protestant Reformation. In that case, I am speaking of important changes in the degree to which the conscience of the individual believer began to claim authority over against that of the Church hierarchy. But my appeal to the significance of this change for the broad story of authority in the modern

West in no way necessarily implies a claim that the Reformation was providential or unambiguously progressive.

Vattimo, however, does have something stronger in mind regarding periodization. He asserts that his form of contesting foundations “entails a philosophy of history” that envisions a process “in which metaphysical Being, meaning violence, consumes itself.”⁴ It is important to be clear about what Vattimo’s rather stunning statement means. “Metaphysical Being” refers to foundationalism or strong ontology; and we are being told, first, that it is violent *in its essence*; and, second, that it is *irredeemably destined* for annihilation.

Now Vattimo is clear that his “antifoundationalism” does not in itself constitute some new, better foundation; it merely tells us that all foundations have the status of interpretations and thus gain their validity only through fallible, deliberative processes.⁵ In a strict sense, Vattimo is correct in his denial; he does not propose one more foundation. And yet his antifoundationalism itself rests on a claim of certainty that functions in a fashion similar to a foundation. The certainty is attached to the claim that his antifoundationalism reflects a higher stage of truth. In this, he is in a position analogous to those who understand secularism as embodying the truth that religion belongs in the trash heap of history. But this option, as critics have pointed out, is itself a kind of foundationalism.⁶

It might be useful here to proffer a terminological distinction. One might use the term Vattimo often employs, “antifoundationalism,” for this *late-modern certainty* as to the falsity of foundations. This claim of falsity, paired with a philosophy of history, constitutes Vattimo’s conception of weak ontology. My conception is somewhat different. The weak ontologist does not know with certainty that strong foundations are false; rather she can merely point to the lack of success of any given foundation in being wholly and universally affirmed by humankind.⁷ This lack of success in the past, however, does not demonstrate that the future will hold merely more of the same. I prefer to call this more modest position “nonfoundationalism.”⁸

My conception of weak ontology differs from Vattimo’s in another way as well. It involves not just the negative claim of nonfoundationalism, but also positive claims that reside in one’s attachment to some set of ontological “figures.” A plausible set of such figures includes a sketch of the self, the other and the beyond-human; and these take shape in the context of some account of at least four existential universals: language, mortality, natality, and the articulation of “sources of the self.”⁹

With this clarification in hand, let me return to the issue of violence. Although Miller tries to associate me at some points with Vattimo’s unfortunate philosophy of history, he nevertheless also admits that my notion of

weak ontology has some additional resources—those fundamental figures to which I just alluded—that might help me to derive a clear opposition to violence and domination. He suspects that I intend this derivation to proceed from some quality that is inherent in a felicitous figuration of those fundamentals. If this is my intention, Miller concludes, it fails in its objective, because the addition of such abstract fundamentals to the nonfoundationalist starting point still does not “close the [logical and motivational] gap” between that starting point and a specific commitment to oppose violence (p. 874). Rather, our commitment to reject or affirm violence in politics must be understood “as *already there*” as part of our specific historical context (p. 877). Miller does not mean to say that adopting a weak ontological stance will have no influence whatsoever on one’s specific political commitments; rather he only wants to preclude the flawed picture of the force of reason flowing directly and conclusively from nonfoundationalist arguments and abstract figures to those concrete normative commitments.

As was the case earlier, here I also find myself in a good deal of agreement with Miller. The fact that he does not see this results from his overly rationalistic comprehension of weak ontology. This systematic misperception undermines Miller’s claims in three ways.

A weak ontology is constituted by a set of ontological figures that are held in a nonfoundationalist fashion. In calling something a “figure” (for example, an account of the self–other relation), I mean to highlight the fact that we do not embrace such an account on the basis of reasoning alone. We also embrace a figure because it appeals to us—like a work of art—in an aesthetic-affective sense. Moreover, the character of this embrace is not such as to give us full cognitive mastery over the figure or all of its possible moral-political implications.¹⁰ This whole field of figures and how we carry them is perceptively illuminated by Charles Taylor’s notion of a “background” of “sources” that I always continue to articulate in my ongoing interactions.¹¹ A key way in which a weak ontology differentiates itself from a strong one is that articulation in the former is understood as never complete. Even our mortality does not complete it; rather it merely ends the process. Hence our figures or sources are never fully fixed in the light of reason.

Given this constitutive inarticulacy, it should be clear why I would never argue that some particular moral-political value, such as opposing violence, could be directly derived from our ontological figures. In *Sustaining Affirmation*, I characterized the relationship only as one of “prefiguration.”¹² The particular figures to which one is committed provide only rough cognitive orientation toward, and affective affinity for, some moral-political values rather than others. They are, one might say, existentially heuristic in relation

to such values. An example might help elucidate this. Assume that I am a nonfoundationalist who finds the figure of “identity/difference” that William Connolly has elucidated to be powerfully persuasive in the purchase it gives me on late-modern moral and political life.¹³ When I embrace such a figure, I can see the sense of, and will likely be attracted to, some formulation of a virtue that has been called “presumptive generosity.”¹⁴ It constitutes a way of dampening the resentment I likely project on a radically different other who threatens my identity.

The hope is that the cultivation of such a virtue might help dry up at least some sources of violence. But an underlying concern to reduce violence is not conjured into full-blown existence by either a nonfoundationalist commitment or a figuration of identity/difference. The underlying aversion to violence or cruelty comes, as Miller—and Richard Rorty—contends, from my specific historical context. What the weak ontologist would insist on here is the importance of our fundamental figurations and prefigured virtues, like presumptive generosity, for enhancing the capacity to engage a complex, late-modern world in a more adequate way. This point about weak ontology’s importance might be driven home by reflecting on the events at Abu Ghraib prison in Iraq in 2003–2004. What strikes me the most about the torture and other abuses committed by Americans there is the realization that one can take an average citizen of one of Rorty’s “rich North Atlantic democracies” who supposedly shares an aversion to gross cruelty and violence and put him in a situation where he will do horrendous things.¹⁵ This realization should make us at least somewhat leery of Rorty’s well-known claim that we can pretty much ignore the efforts of political theorists and have recourse only to the “banal, familiar terms” of liberal public discourse.¹⁶ There may be far more need than he would admit for sustained civic education in which the insights of contemporary political theory, including weak-ontological ones, might function as a valuable part of a mix of possible resources.

A second misunderstanding on Miller’s part involves comprehending nonfoundationalism itself as something like a rational conclusion; that is, as a rational ground to which one has been swept by the force of argument. Thinkers like Vattimo encourage this interpretation, so Miller’s mistake is hardly unusual. The misunderstanding consists in seeing a given weak ontology as purely an artifact of *rational conviction*, as opposed to the *deepest commitment* that I hold. When we think about the commitment to animating figures, we do better to see it as having at least some affinity to the attachment a religious person feels to the fundamentals of her faith. In both cases, the place and force of reason is heavily circumscribed.

We quickly see the inappropriateness of overly rationalist understandings in the case of religion. Recently I purchased a book entitled, *The Savvy Convert's Guide to Choosing a Religion: Compare and Contrast Before You Commit*.¹⁷ The back cover proclaims: "We put more thought into the cars we buy than the Gods we worship—until now!" In a final teaser, we are informed that the volume contains a "Bonus foldout chart showing all 99 religions profiled, side by side." By now you will probably not be surprised to learn that I did not purchase this volume from a religious bookshop, but rather from Cha Cha's Boutique.

The humor lies of course in the book's portrayal of religion as if it were just another choice of some consumer good whose value one determines through rational calculation.¹⁸ But one's most basic commitments, whether religious or weak-ontological, are what animate one's choices and actions; they cannot themselves become, in one fell swoop, the object of that choice. One reason Taylor's model of the articulation of sources is so perceptive is that there is no moment of sovereign choice in ontological reflection; rather we are always already in the process of discovering and creating our sources as we act in the world.

By this point, one can see that the two preceding misunderstandings of weak ontology that I have tried to correct are part of a more general misperception of this form of nonfoundationalism. In Miller's mind, everything about my weak ontology is build up in a linear, rational fashion. First there is the rational choice to be a nonfoundationalist; then there is the derivation of certain ontological figures, followed finally by the further derivation of explicit moral-political values like opposition to violence. But it is relatively easy to see that the Taylorian model I embraced in *Sustaining Affirmation* has a circular, rather than a linear, character. One's explicit actions, judgments, and choices are continually animated by one's background sources, with these sources, in turn, being given further shape and clarity through one's engagement with particular situations.

This process is best understood as one instance of the hermeneutical circle. Yet it is also important to see that something distinctive is in play with this particular loop of the continual circular path between, on the one hand, a specific passage or action that we find puzzling, and the clarifying text, social context, or background, on the other hand. In this variant of the circle, one is engaged in a loop in which "the word breaks off" finally as we encounter our ultimate inarticulacy. The very idea of weak ontology grows out of an interest in exploring this ontological loop of the hermeneutical circle, and how it occupies a space that cannot be comprehended adequately within either a contemporary rationalist framework or a strong-ontological one.

Notes

1. Ted H. Miller, "The Two Deaths of Lady Macduff: Antimetaphysics, Violence and William Davenant's Restoration Revision of *Macbeth*," *Political Theory* (December 2008): 856-82. From this point, I will use in-text page references for this essay.
2. Stephen K. White, *Sustaining Affirmation: The Strengths of Weak Ontology in Political Theory* (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 2000).
3. Gianni Vattimo, *Nihilism and Emancipation: Ethics, Politics, and Law*, ed. Santiago Zaba, trans. William McCuaig, and with a "Forward" by Richard Rorty (New York: Columbia University Press, 2004). See Rorty's "Forward," xviii-xix, and 19.
4. Vattimo, *Nihilism and Emancipation*, 11, 94.
5. Vattimo, *Nihilism and Emancipation*, xxv-xxvi, 94-95.
6. See, for example, William Connolly, *Why I am Not a Secularist?* (Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press, 1999); and Charles Taylor, *A Secular Age* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 2007).
7. White, "Weak Ontology: Genealogy and Critical Issues," in "Commitments in a Post-Foundationalist World: Exploring the Possibilities of 'Weak Ontology,'" Special Issue, *The Hedgehog Review* (Summer 2005): 13.
8. Weak ontology is thus a nonfoundationalism that is modest in two senses: first, it holds that one's most basic commitments regarding self, other, and the beyond human are taken to be both fundamental *and* contestable; and, second, it holds that this contestability extends as well to one's assessments of the strong ontologies of others. See my *Sustaining Affirmation*, 6-8. It is important also not to conflate contestability, on the one hand, and simple uncertainty, in the sense of tentativeness and indecisiveness, on the other. I attempt to make this distinction clearer in *The Ethos of a Late-Modern Citizen* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 2009), 94-97.
9. *Sustaining Affirmation*, 9-10. As I tried to show in that book, this framework can be useful for drawing out some curious commonality between contemporary theorists who may initially appear to share almost nothing.
10. *Sustaining Affirmation*, 8-10; and "Weak Ontology," 16-17.
11. Taylor, *Sources of the Self: The Making of Modern Identity* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1989), Part One. As I argue in *Sustaining Affirmation*, Taylor offers us an example of a weak-ontological theist.
12. *Sustaining Affirmation*, 11; and "Weak Ontology," 17.
13. Connolly, *Identity/Difference: Democratic Negotiations of Political Paradox*, 2nd ed. (Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press, 2002), ix-xxxi, 1-15.
14. See my discussion of this in *The Ethos of a Late-Modern Citizen*, 30-31.

15. See *The Ethos of a Late Modern Citizen*, 60-62.
16. Richard Rorty, "Remarks on Deconstruction and Pragmatism," in *Deconstruction and Pragmatism*, ed. Chantal Mouffe (London: Routledge, 1996), 17.
17. *The Savvy Convert's Guide to Choosing a Religion: Compare and Contrast Before You Commit* (Venice, CA: Knock Knock, 2008).
18. Unsurprisingly, some political scientists have tried to explain religion on the model of rational choice. The limitations of this sort of explanation, as regards the secularization thesis, are pointed out by Pippa Norris and Ronald Inglehart in *Sacred and Secular: Religion and Politics Worldwide* (Cambridge, UK: Cambridge University Press, 2004), 11-13.

Bio

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